

# Implementation Brief — For the Village Conversation

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What to ask them, what they'll ask you, and what it actually costs.

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## Part 1 — Questions to ask the Village

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Ask these before proposing anything. The answers determine cost, timeline, and whether phone integration is a week or a quarter.

### **About their phone system (ask first — everything depends on this)**

1. **"What phone system does the Village use today?"** Listen for: Cisco, Avaya, Mitel, RingCentral, 8x8, Vonage, Zoom Phone, Teams Phone, or "we're not sure."
2. **"Is it on-premise hardware, or cloud/hosted?"** Cloud (RingCentral, 8x8, Zoom, Teams) is much easier — most support SIP forwarding out of the box. On-premise PBX means involving whoever maintains it.
3. **"Who manages it — internal IT, or an outside vendor?"** Determines who you'll actually be coordinating with, and whether changes need a contract amendment.
4. **"What's the main number residents call, and what happens now?"** Auto-attendant? Live receptionist? Voicemail after hours?
5. **"Can that system forward calls to an external number or SIP**

**address?"** ☆ **The single most important technical question.** If yes, integration is straightforward. If no, it's a bigger project.

6. **"Roughly how many calls a day? What are the top five reasons people call?"** Sizes the deployment and tells you which department to pilot.
7. **"When are you busiest — and what happens to calls after hours?"** After-hours coverage is often the easiest win: the AI answers when nobody else can.

## About their content

8. **"Is the website the authoritative source, or does staff know things that aren't published?"** Almost always the latter. That gap is the real project.
9. **"Who owns keeping department information current, and how often does it change?"**
10. **"Do you have a documented FAQ, or is it in people's heads?"**
11. **"How do you use GoGov today — service requests, FAQs, notifications?"**

## About constraints

12. **"Are there policies about resident data leaving Village systems?"** ☆ Determines local vs. cloud AI. Ask early — it can rule out hosted models entirely.
  13. **"Do call recordings or transcripts count as public records under your retention schedule?"** A question for the Village Clerk. Get it on their radar.
  14. **"Who would need to approve this — Board of Trustees, Village Administrator, IT?"**
  15. **"Is there a budget cycle this would need to fit into?"**
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## Part 2 — What phone system they'd need

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**Good news:** almost certainly no new hardware.

### **If they're on a cloud phone system (RingCentral, 8x8, Zoom Phone, Teams)**

**Easiest case.** These support forwarding a number or extension to an external SIP address. You point one number at the AI and it works. Typically a few hours of configuration.

### **If they're on a modern on-premise PBX (Cisco, Avaya, Mitel)**

Workable. These support SIP trunking. Their IT or vendor configures a route to the AI. More coordination, but no replacement.

### **If they're on very old hardware (analog, TDM, no SIP)**

The AI would need its own number instead, published as a separate line — "call this number for automated help with common questions." Avoids touching their system entirely. Also a reasonable *first* step regardless.

## **The honest recommendation for a pilot**

**Don't integrate at all initially.** Get a dedicated number, publish it for one department, and route to the AI. That:

- Requires zero changes to Village infrastructure
- Contains the risk — the main line is untouched
- Gives real usage data before anyone commits
- Can be turned off instantly

Then integrate properly once it's proven.

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## Part 3 — Can the free version actually be deployed?

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Partly, and it's worth being precise about which parts.

### What genuinely stays free forever

| Component                              | Notes                                |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| The software                           | All of it. Open source, no licensing |
| Local models (Ollama, Whisper, Kokoro) | Free regardless of call volume       |
| Vector database (Qdrant)               | Free, self-hosted                    |
| PostgreSQL                             | Free                                 |
| Frontend hosting                       | Vercel free tier is sufficient       |

**Marginal cost per call: \$0.** That's genuinely unusual and worth emphasizing — most vendors charge per minute.

### What can never be free

| Component                 | Why                              | Cost                                        |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| A phone number            | Carriers charge for connectivity | ~\$1–2/month                                |
| Inbound minutes           | Same                             | ~\$0.0085–0.013/min                         |
| A server that's always on | Something must host it           | \$0 if Village hardware; ~\$70–250/mo cloud |

|            |                                        |                       |
|------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Staff time | Verifying content, reviewing questions | The largest real cost |
|------------|----------------------------------------|-----------------------|

### The honest verdict

**The free stack can run in production**, on a Village server, with no per-call AI cost. What it needs first is the work in `SECURITY_ROADMAP.md`: authentication, encryption, audit logging, PII handling. That's engineering time, not licensing.

**What "free" does not mean:** free of effort. Village staff must verify every answer the system can give. That's unavoidable with any vendor, and it's the step most likely to be underestimated.

## Part 4 — Cost breakdown

### Option A — Fully local, Village-hosted (maximum privacy)

| Item                                  | One-time         | Monthly      |
|---------------------------------------|------------------|--------------|
| Server (or existing Village hardware) | \$0–2,500        | \$0          |
| Software                              | \$0              | \$0          |
| AI usage                              | \$0              | <b>\$0</b>   |
| Phone number + ~3,000 min/mo          | —                | ~\$40        |
| <b>Total</b>                          | <b>\$0–2,500</b> | <b>~\$40</b> |

Best when policy forbids resident data leaving Village systems. Needs someone to maintain the server.

### Option B — Hybrid (recommended starting point)

Local models for routine questions; a hosted model only for hard ones.

| Item                       | Monthly           |
|----------------------------|-------------------|
| Cloud VM                   | ~\$80             |
| Hosted LLM (~20% of turns) | ~\$15–40          |
| Managed database           | ~\$25             |
| Phone                      | ~\$40             |
| <b>Total</b>               | <b>~\$160–185</b> |

Faster than fully local, far cheaper than fully hosted. Requires a data processing agreement with the model vendor.

**Option C — Fully managed (fastest, least control)**

| Item                                     | Monthly           |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Hosted LLM                               | ~\$60–150         |
| Managed speech-to-text + text-to-speech  | ~\$90–150         |
| Container hosting + database + vector DB | ~\$110            |
| Phone                                    | ~\$40             |
| <b>Total</b>                             | <b>~\$300–450</b> |

Assumes ~100 calls/day at ~3 minutes.

**For comparison**

Commercial AI receptionist platforms typically run **\$0.10–0.25 per minute**. At 100 calls/day × 3 min ≈ 9,000 min/month, that's **\$900–2,250/month** — and you don't control the knowledge base or the refusal behavior.

**The pitch:** comparable capability at roughly a tenth of the cost, with the

Village owning the system.

The cost people forget

| Item                                   | Estimate                    |
|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Staff verifying content                | 20–40 hours up front        |
| Ongoing review of unanswered questions | 1–2 hours/week              |
| Engineering to production-ready        | 6–10 weeks                  |
| Legal/records review                   | A few hours of counsel time |

Part 5 — Proposed plan to present

**Phase 0 — Today.** Prototype exists. Answers from the live Village site, refuses when it doesn't know, routes to nine departments.

**Phase 1 — Content validation (2–4 weeks, mostly Village staff).** Staff verify what it can answer, fill gaps, populate department contacts. *Deliverable: a knowledge base the Village stands behind.* Highest value, least technical, and it de-risks everything after.

**Phase 2 — Hardening (3–4 weeks, engineering).** Authentication, encryption, audit logging, PII redaction, backups, monitoring. *Deliverable: a system that can legally handle real calls.*

**Phase 3 — Phone pilot (2–3 weeks).** A dedicated number for **one** department — sanitation is ideal: highest volume, factual answers, low stakes. Human fallback always available. *Deliverable: real residents, real data, contained risk.*

**Phase 4 — Measured expansion.** Add departments only as each meets an accuracy bar. Weekly review of unanswered questions.

**Total to a live pilot: roughly 8–11 weeks**, most of it Village staff time rather than engineering.

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## **Part 6 — Questions they will ask, and how to answer**

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### **"What if it gives someone wrong information?"**

The main design decision was refusing over guessing. It only answers when retrieval strongly supports it, and a second check verifies the answer against the source before it's spoken. When it can't, it hands off. Every answer cites its source, so anything wrong is traceable to a page you can fix. And it's never the only option — a person is always reachable.

### **"Is this replacing staff?"**

No. It handles the repetitive questions — hours, schedules, where to apply — so staff spend time on things that need judgment. It routes *to* staff; it can't do their work. Most Villages find it useful for after-hours and peak times, when the alternative is voicemail.

### **"Where does resident data go?"**

Right now, nowhere. Everything runs on this laptop. In production, that's your choice — fully local means no data leaves Village systems. There's no caller name, phone number, or address stored anywhere, and transcripts delete after seven days by default.

### **"How does it stay current?"**

Two ways. It re-reads the Village website on a schedule. And when staff answer something it couldn't, they approve that answer and it's available immediately. The system can't change its own knowledge — only your people can.

### **"What happens when it breaks?"**



Calls route to a person, exactly as today. It's an addition to the phone tree, not a replacement for it. There's a kill switch.

### **"How much?"**

Depends on where it runs. Roughly \$40/month fully local on Village hardware, to about \$400/month fully managed. Commercial alternatives run \$900–2,000+ at your volume. The bigger cost is staff time verifying content.

### **"How long?"**

About 8–11 weeks to a live pilot on one department. Most of that is your team confirming the information is right, not engineering.

### **"Can it handle Spanish?"** (*likely in Nassau County*)

The speech and language models support it. It would need Spanish content and testing — a real piece of work, not a checkbox, but well within scope.

### **"What about accessibility?"**

Important and not yet addressed. Callers using relay services or with atypical speech need a guaranteed path to a person. That's a requirement for any deployment, and worth naming as an open item rather than glossing over.

### **"Who else is doing this?"**

Municipal AI assistants are early. Worth answering honestly: this is a prototype built to show what's feasible, not a product with a customer list. The advantage is the Village would own it.

### **"Can we see it fail?"**

Yes — say yes enthusiastically. Ask it something obscure and let them watch it decline. That demo is more convincing than any successful answer.

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## Part 7 — What to be upfront about

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Credibility comes from naming these before they're found:

1. **Not production-ready.** No authentication, no encryption at rest, no audit trail.
2. **Content is unverified.** Read off the public website; nobody at the Village has confirmed it.
3. **Department phone numbers are deliberately blank.** They weren't guessed. They need to come from the official directory.
4. **Response time is 3–8 seconds locally.** A hosted model is under a second. That's a cost decision.
5. **No phone number yet.** Browser only. Telephony is a known, scoped piece of work.
6. **One caller at a time** in the current setup. Concurrency needs a server.

Saying these first makes everything else you claim more believable.